



CARLIN STIEHL For The Times

STREET ART

Where LACMA’S new structure stretches over Wilshire Boulevard, a permanent video installation of Monet’s garden by Diana Thater, the first such project in a public space, is tested. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Faculty at UC urge the return of SATs

STEM students show ‘severe’ math deficits, says an open letter calling for the tests.

By JAWEED KALEEM

More than 600 University of California faculty members, led by mathematicians at UC Berkeley, are calling on the system to reinstate standardized testing requirements for science, technology, engineering and mathematics applicants, saying that six years of test-free admissions has not reliably assessed readiness and professors are often teaching middle school math to incoming students.

Without standardized testing in admissions, professors said they don’t know whether incoming students can handle college-level math. The open letter, addressed to top UC leaders, asks for SAT or ACT exams to be required beginning in fall 2027 and for STEM faculty to be given formal oversight of readiness standards in their majors.

“We now observe preparation gaps so severe that instructors must reteach middle-school mathematics while simultaneously teaching the material students need for sciences, engineering, economics, and other quantitatively demanding fields,” they warned.

Over three years — from fall 2021 to fall 2023 — the letter said, at least 20% of Berkeley first-semester calculus students who took a diagnostic exam showed deficits. “Basic mathematical fluency is analogous to literacy; without it, success in university-level STEM becomes structurally unattainable for students,” faculty wrote.

The open letter lands days before the UC Academic Senate’s Board of Admissions and Relations with Schools is scheduled to discuss systemwide admissions changes, which could be the first step toward a possible return of standardized testing at the nation’s largest public research university system.

UC gained national attention in May 2020 when regents unanimously voted to suspend SAT and ACT testing requirements and eliminate them entirely by 2025. Board members cited concerns the tests were biased against students of color and those from lower-income families — including students who did not have access to prep courses.

[See UC, A7]

Garden Grove crisis exposes industrial risks

SoCal’s legacy: Homes next to hazardous plants

By Hayley Smith

The days-long threat of a catastrophic chemical explosion in Garden Grove has exposed the pervasive yet often ignored industrial risks hidden amid daily life in Southern California, where aerospace plants and petrochemical facilities are interwoven among homes, schools and parks.

Now, experts say this aging infrastructure is converging with population growth and regulatory rollbacks that are increasing the likelihood that similar incidents will happen again.

The Greater Los Angeles area became a global hub for aerospace and defense manufacturing around the start of World War II, with companies here producing military aircraft, electronics, plastics, petroleum products and other specialized materials that helped transform the re-

gion into a dense manufacturing zone even as its suburban footprint was expanding.

Many of those operations used petrochemical products and solvents such as resins, adhesives and acrylic compounds like methyl methacrylate, the chemical at the center of the Orange County crisis.

While some of that work has slowed since the end of the Cold War, many industrial sites remain active and tucked among communities.

That makes the possibility of another Garden Grove incident a matter of “if,” not when, said Seth Shonkoff, executive director at the science research institute PSE Healthy Energy.

“It’s not really whether industrial accidents are pos-

[See Risks, A13]

Private money and access to LAPD

Wealthy boosters who supplement budget reportedly gain perks from the department.

By LIBOR JANY

The check was relatively small — just \$15,000 — but within the Los Angeles Police Department it seemed to go a long way.

The funds came last year from the LAPD Valley Bureau Foundation, a nonprofit it that supports police causes in the San Fernando Valley. The organization has donated sporadically in re-

cent years, according to Police Commission records, mostly bankrolling holiday parties and other smaller events aimed at boosting officer morale. Recently, the foundation chipped in to help upgrade the sound system at an LAPD training facility.

The modest track record of giving has seemingly enabled the organization’s founder to gain extraordinary access to the LAPD’s upper echelons, according to two LAPD sources familiar with the Valley Bureau Foundation who, like several others interviewed for this article, requested anonymity because they were not au-

thorized to speak publicly.

Founder Larry Stearn, 71, is a longtime LAPD booster and the owner of a Porter Ranch mortgage company who regularly hosts LAPD chiefs and other high-ranking officials at his Thousand Oaks home for Super Bowl parties and fundraising events, according to the sources and photos from the occasions.

Stearn, the sources said, has grown especially close with command staff in the Valley, who have invited him to attend police recruit graduations as their guest.

When the daughter of one of the foundation’s board members had a vehicle

crash at her property last fall, rather than go through the normal process of reporting the incident, someone from the foundation’s board called a senior LAPD commander for help, according to three police sources.

The commander, John Shah, asked one of his community service officers to go out to the scene to take a report — an unusual request given the minor nature of the incident and the department’s officer shortage, the sources said.

Shah did not respond to a request for comment.

Stearn declined an interview. [See LAPD, A8]

Crowded race for county sheriff

Robert Luna is up for reelection. He faces 7 challengers, including the man he replaced.

By CONNOR SHEETS

Los Angeles County Sheriff Robert Luna unseated his predecessor Alex Villanueva in a hard-fought campaign four years ago. Next week, Villanueva hopes to return the favor.

Villanueva is one of seven candidates challenging Luna’s hopes for a second term in Tuesday’s primary. Also making a return appearance is Eric Strong, a retired sheriff’s lieutenant who came in third in the 2022 primary.

If no candidate gets a majority in the primary, the top two vote-getters will square off Nov. 3.

The electoral confrontation between Luna and Villanueva, the top money draws in this year’s packed primary, has echoes of their showdown in November 2022. Luna garnered more than 61% of the countywide vote to defeat Villanueva, who drew less than 39% of votes.

There has been no publicly released polling on this year’s sheriff’s race. But a quality of life survey conducted between March 15 and 29 asked 1,400 people across L.A. County about the sheriff.

Luna’s favorability in that annual index, produced by the UCLA Luskin School of Public Affairs in partner-

[See Sheriff, A7]



NATALIA FAVRE For The Times

CUBAN RESISTANCE

Island’s deputy foreign minister says the U.S. risks bloodshed if it abandons dialogue in their conflict. Above, a street in Havana. **WORLD, A3**

O.C. evacuation orders are lifted

All residents can return as officials say there is no more threat of a chemical explosion. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Morning mist.
L.A. Basin: 71/56. **B5**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A14**

Shades of Apple in this supercar

Ferrari fans say its first fully electric vehicle looks more like an iPhone. **BUSINESS, A11**

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